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Herbie Hancock

Pianist, composer and synthesist Herbie Hancock has had a profound influence on American music since the early 1960s. As a composer, he has written numerous songs that have become part of the standard repertoire of jazz, including "Maiden Voyage" and "Watermelon Man." His piano playing has been part of some of the most memorable recordings in the last thirty years, including those with the Miles Davis Quintet and duets with Chick Corea as well as his own small group recordings. As a synthesist, Herbie has been responsible for combining jazz and rock into his own distinctive style which has enabled jazz to cross into the coveted exposure usually reserved for the three minute pop song. He continues to be an active and ever-evolving force on the music scene.

Herbie was interviewed by Michael Woods on November 18, 1995 in New York City.

MW: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. We have with us today one of the American icons in jazz — Herbie Hancock.

HH: Hi there, Mike.

MW: Great, great. I want to just kind of let, say a few little questions and just kind of let you roll on. You were a prodigy.

HH: That's a funny word. I'm starting to hear people use that more and more now in reference to me and my early life in music. But I never, I mean I think that way about some other people but never about myself, you know? I just did what I do. I started when I was seven, but you know I think that's, I don't know if that's an average age, it may be an average age, it's probably close to average for starting to learn to play an instrument. I've heard of people starting to play instruments as early as three. Now I guess with the Suzuki Method and some other methods, they start at one. When they come out of the womb they're starting. But anyway, I seemed to be able to able to catch on to reading fairly quickly when I was young. My first teacher, which her name was Mrs. Whalen, and she taught me for two and a half years. She was the church organist for the Baptist church and I took lessons in the second floor of the Baptist church you know. And that was the church I belonged to at that time. Anyway, she didn't teach me very much about dynamics. So I could only play at one volume level, and that was fairly loud. I didn't know anything about playing soft, nothing about touch, nothing about nuances, and nothing about the history of music. I just learned to read what the notes were. And then I got a new teacher, Mrs. Jordan. And I remember sort of, it's not exactly auditioning for her, but she wanted to hear, you know, hear me play something so she could tell what

teach you anything about dynamics?" I said, "What?" And she said, "You know loud and soft?" Anyway then she played some Chopin. And my eyes bugged out. I said, "How do you do that? I want to play like that." Because it was so beautiful the way she was playing. She had the dynamics and it was colorful and it had shape to it. It wasn't just plink, plink, plink, plink you know. That's what I was playing before — plink, plink, plink, plink, plink. That's all it was.

MW: So something had to mesmerize you to draw you into that next level.

HH: Yeah. It was a feeling. That's what did it, the feeling.

MW: Now tell us about your debut with the symphony.

HH: Well that was during the time that I was with Mrs. Jordan, the second teacher. By that time I was playing Bach inventions, some fugues and preludes and some Chopin. I had gotten into etudes and I think maybe Chopin's "Fantasie Impromptu," some things like that. So in 1950 — actually 1950, is that right? No — 1951 I auditioned for this — basically it was a concert. The Young People's Concert Series in Chicago. And what would happen is that you would audition for who was then the Assistant Conductor of the Chicago Symphony. And that was George Schick, who became President of Manhattan School of Music later on by the way. Anyway, so they would select one person from each instrument of the orchestra who would be a winner, and I happened to win for the piano. And the prize would be to play a concerto with the Chicago Symphony. Anyway, I won. And then, well the way I found out that I won was that I received a post card in the mail about two months later, that said, "Congratulations, you've been selected as the piano winner of the Young People's Concert Series, however," — oh by the way, the date you are to perform is February 5, 1952 I think it was. Or 1951, I've forgotten. And maybe I auditioned in '50 and played in '51. But anyway, so anyway it said, "However the concerto that you auditioned with, somehow we haven't been able to locate the orchestral parts, so you'll either have to learn a new concerto or forfeit the performance just so you know you are a winner but you won't be able to play with the Chicago Symphony." So I had to learn a new concerto you know? And that other one I knew cold. The new one I had to learn in about three months so I didn't have nearly as much time. And so I made the performance, and as a matter of fact after the performance I signed the first autograph that I ever signed, you know. But the next week — oh I should say that the performance was at the Chicago Symphony Orchestra. And the next week my teacher had gotten herself and me tickets to see Myra Hess, who was a very famous classical pianist at the time, who was performing with the Chicago Symphony Orchestra. So we went that week to see Myra Hess, guess what she played? The concerto that I auditioned with. So all of that nonsense that they said about not being able to find the parts was a bunch of bologna.

HH: My teacher was mad. I thought she was going to tear that place up she was so mad. I mean she said to me, how could they do that to a little kid?

MW: When did you get started moving into jazz? When did you make the transition? And what was the catalyst for the transition?

HH: It was about 1953 or '54 when I was either thirteen or fourteen years old. The funny thing is that I had been listening to rhythm & blues before that. And I was hanging out with the kids my age of course and that's what they listened to and that's what I listened to, and I also listened to classical music too. My mother wanted to give me quote culture. She wanted to make sure her children were quote cultured. And what that meant was really European culture you know. And what it certainly did was give me a pretty well-rounded cultural foundation, so I'm happy about the way things really turned out. Because I can use all of that in playing jazz and then it also gives me an avenue of being involved with classical music if the desire is there and the opportunity arises. So I've got a whole spectrum of things that are part of my foundation. Anyway my mother was a very important, the most important influence on me as far as not only support but being able to push me, move me forward. Because I had a tendency to kind of lay back and be a little shy you know. And she would just push me on out there. And I'm glad she did you know. Anyway, I noticed in high school that the kids that were the most mature acting and the coolest and the most mysterious were the ones that listened to jazz.

MW: Aha.

HH: And I said I want to be like that. So I started hanging out with them. And you hang out with them, they're listening to jazz. So that was one of the things. That was one of the things. There was another very important thing too. There was a pianist named Don Goldberg who performed at the variety show that my school used to give every semester. And he had a jazz trio. And he was my age, he was in my class, and I heard him improvising and I was shocked first of all. It sounded, I didn't know what he was doing. Because I always used to turn jazz off whenever it was on the radio, because I didn't understand it and I didn't want to know anything about it, I didn't care about it, I didn't like it. But when I saw this guy improvising and it sounded organized to me. I didn't know what he was doing but it sounded like he knew what he was doing. Then I became fascinated. 'Cause he was doing it on my instrument and he was my age. I thought you had to be much older to play jazz you know, like nineteen or something. But he was doing it. And so I started hanging out with this guy and asking him what is he listening to, how does he learn that, how do you do these things. And so at the time, his favorite pianist and the person he tried to emulate was George Shearing. So I remember going home telling my mother, "Mama, you've got to get me some George Shearing records."

don't understand. I want to get some George Shearing records. I got to find out how to do this improvising you know." She said, "Herbie, remember those records I bought for you about two years ago and you got angry with me because you didn't know who it was and there were some other records you wanted and you had a tantrum about seeing these records for Christmas?" I said, "Yeah." She said, "That was George Shearing. And you've got those records in your cabinet." So I went in the cabinet and sure enough, they were there. My mother had no idea that that was going to be the first jazz artist I would ask about. It just was—

MW: Let me make a quantum there 'cause I want to hook in on something that you said. You said the kids that you were hanging out with who were the hippest, the most mature and the most mysterious that's what turned you on. So now from your entrance into jazz to the place where you would be asked to play keyboard with the hippest most mysterious man in all of jazz. You know we're talking about Miles. Tell us about how you got to work with Miles and how that liaison came about and some of the dynamics in there.

HH: All right. I was brought to New York from Chicago by Donald Byrd, another great trumpeter. And Donald really took me under his wing and we shared an apartment together, he was my roommate and he was like really a big brother to me. And he really showed me the ropes in New York and he really encouraged me in so many ways and taught me a lot of things. And was the person responsible for me doing my very first record as a leader. He is responsible for me getting my own publishing company so that my first tunes were published in my own company, and not in the record company's company. Thank goodness for that because one of the first tunes I wrote was "Watermelon Man."

MW: Which is still played today.

HH: It's still played today. And he was also responsible for introducing me to Miles Davis. So I owe a lot to Donald Byrd. I mean so much that I could never repay him for what he's done for me.

MW: Somebody has to give you that hand, don't they?

HH: Sometimes not. Sometimes, well there's always some kind of opportunity one way or the other. One way or the other, whether there's somebody taking you somewhere, or whether a door being opened when something is needed and you happen to be at the right place at the right time. But in very, very many cases, maybe most cases, there is a person that gives you a chance somehow. Sometimes it's a person that gives you inspiration. You never know. That's why, by the way, it's so important to not think of our lives as being trivial and not think of our daily life, just because we don't have anything, doesn't mean that we can't be a great influence on someone who could have a dynamic influence

MW: That is an awesome statement. That's a conversation within itself.

HH: Everybody's important.

MW: I'm going to put that one on hold and we gonna come back there. Jump on Miles. I'm gonna keep that in reserve and we going to finish with that 'cause that's a mouthful.

HH: So Donald introduced me to Miles about a year and a half or two years prior to my joining Miles' band. But the way I actually got into Miles' band, I had been hearing rumors that Miles was looking for me. And finally I had started hearing so many rumors that I began to believe it because at first I said, "Come on, get out of here, Miles Davis calling me?" Forget it. That will never happen. I mean I had never even dreamed of playing with Miles. That was beyond my fondest dreams. And anyway so Donald Byrd, again, because he was my roommate, said, "If Miles calls you, tell him you're not working with anybody." I said, "But Donald, I owe you so much." He said, "Shut up, man." He said, "I would never stand in the way of you having such a great opportunity like that." He says, "Tell him you're not working with anybody." And it was almost within about an hour, the phone rang and it was Miles. First question Miles asked was, "Are you working with anybody?" And I looked at Donald and I said, "No." And then he invited me to his house the next day at 2:30 I think it was. Click. And he hung up the phone. I didn't know his phone number. Fortunately I knew Donald Byrd knew where he lived, but I started to panic. And then a half hour later, Tony Williams, a great drummer, called me. And it turned out that Miles had called him too. And he had Miles' address and everything, so the next day we went to Miles' place. And Miles ushered us into his basement, his rec room there. And Ron Carter the bassist was there, and George Coleman, the tenor saxophonist, he was there. And Tony Williams and myself. And Miles. And Miles didn't pick up his horn. He just said, "Play some of these" I think he got Ron to kind of lead this, what I thought was an audition, and he says, "Play some of these tunes." There were some new tunes they were working on I guess. And then Miles split. He went upstairs somewhere. And so we started playing these tunes and they had music there. This went on for three days. And I saw Miles maybe twice in those three days. And once Gil Evans and Philly Jo Jones came down. Gil Evans, who did these incredible arrangements of "Porgy & Bess" and "Sketches of Spain," "Miles Ahead," a bunch of things. Anyway and Philly Jo Jones, who was Miles' former drummer. They came down. And by the way I found out much later that Miles was upstairs in one of his other rooms listening to us play over the intercom. So I think he suspected that if he had been there we would have felt intimidated. So he wasn't there, he was away, we didn't even know where he was. So he could really hear what we could do. Anyway, after the third day, he came downstairs and he said, "Okay, tomorrow we meet at 3:30 at

that studio, but I'd never recorded there. And I said, I was just shocked. And I said, "Miles, does that mean I'm in the band?" And he said, "You're making the record." And then he smiled. And the one statement he made that gave me the most indication that he liked what was going on, because he hadn't said anything yet, nothing complimentary, nothing. At the studio, we walked in there, and Teo Macero, who was the producer, came in to the booth, the recording booth, and Miles said, "Hey Teo, listen to this." And I could tell by Miles' face he was just champing at the bit to show Teo his new band. And so we kicked off one of the tunes. I think it was "Seven Steps to Heaven." And Teo almost fell off his chair, he couldn't believe it. Because it was a very exciting group you know, and Tony at the time was seventeen years old. So he was — talking about a prodigy, that's the prodigy. And he was a real phenomenon. And we played there, and then we recorded the album "Seven Steps to Heaven," and the following week we played our first gig. I played Bowdoin College in Maine. And I was there for five and a half years after that.

MW: Wow. I want to contrast something just too, and have you talk about the experience. The experience of being ushered into the basement that first day and then the experience of being the one chosen — I saw the ceremony — to give Miles the Lifetime Achievement Award. I was touched by that. Tell us about that.

HH: Well by the time I was able to give Miles the Lifetime Achievement Award from, I guess that was from NARAS from the Grammy Awards Ceremony. NARAS is the National Academy of Recording Arts and Sciences. It's the Academy Award for the recording industry. Anyway, by that time I had my own career going. I had even done some acting on television. I think I had already had a T.V. show called "Rock School" at the time, which came, and we did a couple of seasons of that and then that went. There was another show I had too, called "Coast to Coast" it was on Showtime. I'm not sure whether that was before my presenting this award to Miles or not, but anyway I'm just saying that by then I'd kind of grown up and had my own things going and had been a presenter several times also for the Grammys. So I was selected by Mike Green, who is the President of NARAS and, I think he was president at that time, and maybe there was a committee, but I was asked to do that. Probably because I had been a former member of Miles' band and they could trust that I knew how to deliver that.

MW: It was a touching moment, and not much was said but there was an electricity there.

HH: Well I know what Miles means to me personally. And I know what he means to music and what he means to the public at large. And so in giving this Lifetime Achievement to Miles, I wasn't just reading what was on the teleprompter. I mean I was reading that, but I meant every word that I said. Because I had something of my own experience with this man who was like my teacher, like my father in a way you know as far as my career was

had it not been for that experience in playing with that particular Miles Davis group, you know. Because of Miles and because of all the side men. One of the things that Miles provided, among many things, is the attitude to really encourage an individual to develop his creativity. And he was very concerned about young people. He hired a very young band and he wanted us to figure things out ourselves. He wanted us to continually work on things. I mean he even said, "I pay you to practice on the bandstand, on the stage, in front of the people, not just in your room." You know the idea was not just to go to your room and practice something and learn it perfectly and then play it in front of the people. Miles wanted true jazz improvisation to be presented by this band, which means you captured that moment, not the moment in your room hours earlier. And so that's a lesson I've never forgotten. And it sustains me to this day.

MW: Yeah. I want to come in on one other thing. You know some people believe that the piano duets that you've done with Chick basically took pianistic virtuosity in terms of improvisation to its zenith. And some people said it hasn't gone past that since.

HH: Wow.

MW: Talk to us about the, you know, the two of you like spurring each other on, learning from each other, just like the virtuosity of the language, you know.

HH: We — Chick and I — I should say about when we first got together to do the first tour, you know, when we first got together to rehearse, neither one of us had done anything quite like that before. He had done some duets I guess with his, well his then-girlfriend, now wife, Gayle Moran, who was working in his band and she's also a singer. But there was sort of a different story because she hadn't had the same kinds of experiences. She wasn't like a heavyweight piano player per se, that wasn't what she was about. Anyway Chick had two pianos in his house and — two big Steinways I guess they were or maybe a Bosendorfer and a Steinway concert grands — which was fortunate. That way we didn't have to pay for a rehearsal studio and we didn't have to rent pianos. It was great. And then we could just take our time and still really relax. But I was a little nervous about it and Chick was a little nervous about it too because we both really respected each other. You know we're both contemporaries. And so we decided to take a tune, I don't remember which tune it was, but we were both so cautious in the beginning. But it was funny to notice that that became easy. So then we would each start to take a few more chances. And that became easy. And then we started being less and less polite you know. Because at first we were so polite. You know I would play something and then I would wait to hear what Chick was going to play and really try to follow him you know, and leave him a lot of space. And he'd leave me space. It got to the point where we didn't have to leave each other any space. We could both just play simultaneously and it didn't

thought." It just happens that Chick and I just really fit each other. Somehow it just works. It's amazing, you know, really amazing. I've had the great fortune also to play five concerts opposite Oscar Peterson but we played a couple of things together. So I mean that was a great opportunity for me. He's one of the people that was a major influence on me when I was coming up. That's a little more difficult, playing with Oscar. Maybe because he has been his own man for so long that he's used to doing certain kinds of things and this is pretty far removed from what he's accustomed to. But still, we were able to find a common ground and get something going. But with Chick it's effortless. I don't even have to think about him being, about providing a space for him you know. So it was really fantastic. And you're right, we would feed each other constantly. I've got some stories I could tell you about some funny concerts. One time during the tour it became so easy to play together that we started trying to find other devices to use to kind of just a combination of either, like throwing a monkey wrench into the works just to give us something to deal with.

MW: Just to make a save?

HH: Yeah. Exactly. So we started getting into playing inside the piano you know, and doing things like that, a combination of the two, and different effects, and then hitting, then we started hitting the sounding board and hitting the metal part, the harp of the piano, using that for rhythm. And I remember one concert, I think it was in Hamburg. We played the concert and the next morning the newspaper comes out and there's a picture of Chick and I. Chick was in the piano, knees and everything. I mean he had crawled into the piano, I was under the piano on my back, banging on the sounding board, and we were actually, things had just gone that far. We were making music with rhythm using other parts of the piano. I mean it was amazing. We would use physical gestures sometimes. We'd get into where we were playing things and I'd do this, and then he would do this, or then he would do this. And then there were eye movements, you know. Up and down and you know, and that became part of it, and different things. And then you know he would do, but we would make it as though it were music. We'd make some kind of pattern, organized patterns out of it. And integrate that, those kind of body movements, with the notes that we were playing. And it made some sense. Once we played at the Montreaux Jazz Festival and this was incredible. We got so many standing ovations it was amazing. It got to the point where by the third or fourth or fifth standing ovation, we decided not to even go to the pianos. So I took a chair, set it down in the middle of the stage, Chick sat in the chair and I sat next to him, and we, for the last final encore, we never even touched the pianos. We were making sounds with our mouth, and doing things with gestures, and all kinds of things. And the people went crazy. They loved it. And because we had kind

great thing to experience for me. And we wound up actually doing two tours. One was in '76 and I think the other one was in 1978. So we had a great time together. And then we did a, we actually did a short tour in Brazil, and I've forgotten what year that was, Brazil and some other parts of South America, in the '80s.

MW: I've got one final question, because I realize we've got to let you go because you've got to perform tonight. Just talk to us a little bit, feedback, concepts, insights, on your being one of the icons and one of the spearheads of the whole electronic revolution and its ways it either bonds with jazz or dissects jazz or is jazz.

HH: I started playing piano when I was seven. But when I was five I was already building model boats and planes and taking apart things like watches. And I was always curious about how things worked. I'm the same way with people. People fascinate me. I'm always asking them questions and trying to find out what makes them tick. And so I've always had this kind of interest in science. As a matter of fact, when I was in college, my first major was electrical engineering, before I switched to music composition. And so when synthesizers came along, it fulfilled something for my life that I never dreamed would be possible, and that is to combine science and music in some kind of way. So I naturally gravitated toward that, because I've always been interested in technology. And I've always been interested in orchestration too, so a synthesizer to me is a tool for making instruments. It doesn't have any sound until you program something into it. You know? So it's like the hammer and the nails, and the wood. You have to have that and then you can make an instrument. And so I can use it as a kind of a orchestration tool. But then since then, there have been other technologies involving computers and sequencing and midi came along. Midi is a way for, I know, this is funny because I was fooling with electronics and music before midi came along. Midi means Musical Instrument Digital Interface. What I noticed is that if I have an album, I think it's the "Sunlight" album. On the back of this album is all these keyboards, I mean full of keyboards. There's no way I can get around to all those keyboards. So I remember telling instrument manufacturers, "Why don't you guys figure out a way to get these instruments to talk to each other" so that — I mean a person only has two hands. I could hear that I'd like this to happen and that to happen, but I can't get to them all. But if you could figure out an electronic way to get the instruments to talk to each other, then I could play one instrument, and it could actually trigger the sounds on other instruments. So anyway, I guess enough people started talking about that that they took it seriously and they actually formed an alliance which allowed them to make certain standards and make a protocol called Midi. And that led to some other ideas that we never even thought of — that we could start making keyboards that didn't have keys, just modules, you know. Well they're

it doesn't have keys, you know? But I've got a rack with about, it has other things in it too but it's got about five or six different like keyboards and modular instruments that can be talked to from another single keyboard. And it gives me the opportunity to, like I said arrange. And also sequencers, which came out of music and computer technology, gave me a chance to — maybe I should explain what that is — a sequencer remembers the notes that I play. And it's stored in the computer and then it can play back those same codes that contain the notes and play it back through the instrument so that I can listen back to what I played on the very instrument that I played it on. The computer plays it the second time if I put it in a playback mode. And now we can have different tracks. Now they have multi-track recording on the computer. Tapeless recording. Where an instrument gets put into your hard disk. And so this has opened up all kinds of new possibilities for recording in your home. I mean all these parallels are happening also in business, in the business world too, you know. A lot of people are now able to work at home and have computer terminals at home and have them connected through a modem or other device to the office machines, and so it just kind of expands this idea of a virtual office. It's the same thing like a virtual studio. Now that idea of a virtual studio is really taking shape because now it's possible, although this technology is very new, to be able to overdub on a recording and not be in the city that's recording it. It's remote recording, where you can have a recording session in New York, musicians can lay down certain tracks, and if say they wanted me to overdub a part on that recording on a different track, I can be in Los Angeles, listen to the tracks that have been recorded on, through a high speed telephone linkage, and record from my studio, back through the phone, on to the tape that's in New York. As a matter of fact I have a set up in my studio now that allows me to do something like that. It just got set up just before I came to — no it's not even set up yet, it was brought to the studio before I came to New York. You know so I haven't had a chance to use it there. We did use the same device actually, last night at the Blue Note. Dolby has this device called Dolby Fax Pro and it allows you to send music, high quality sound, down a telephone line. That's a higher speed line than the regular line, it's called an ISDN line. But it's not very expensive, those ISDN lines, and they allow you to really go more than, put more than your toll into the world of, the new world of technology and start getting into the information highway. By the way I should tell you that I'm launching a foundation.

MW: Tell us about that.

HH: And the idea of the foundation, the overview pertains to technology for humanity. Because I've noticed that the world of technology is going through the roof. It's amazing the things that are possible. And the importance that technology is going to play in

know, it makes education fun — and communications and also in the workplace for business — teleconferencing, for home entertainment, television, telephone — I mean all these things are going to be really linked up together in the very near future.

MW: What is the foundation called?

HH: I'm sorry?

MW: What will it be called?

HH: The foundation is called The Rhythm of Life Foundation. And I look at programs like CNN and other news programs and I see what's happening to humanity. Humanity is in pretty bad shape you know. And so I'm thinking, something's wrong with this picture. If the measure of the value of something, isn't it supposed to be what it does for humanity? It should be that anyway. Then what is technology doing for humanity if humanity is in the toilet and technology is going through the roof? So there is something wrong with that picture and so I think there needs to be a lot more balance between the typical approach to technology, which is to look at machines first and figure out what kind of tools can we make from these machines? Then takes those tools to human beings and say how can you use these? And the human being says oh I can use it for this or for that. Meanwhile, the real issues that are the real problems for human beings which have to do with the fact that responsibility, which is something that's part of the fiber of life, that's almost totally lacking in society today, and across the board, with adults and with our young people, a sense of responsibility. Things like courage, self worth, mutual respect, you name it, I mean so many of these things need to be nurtured, need to be encouraged, and even the decision making process you know, this idea of having a very short view of life needs to be re-examined and changed so we have a much longer view so we can have a sense of the results of what the results of our actions can lead to. Promoting that kind of follow through and thinking about your life. So anyway, what this foundation wants to do is to propose that the technical, technological community spent at least some kind of balance of time looking at humanity first and saying how can I use technology to address the needs of humanity? And develop software and ideas from that standpoint.

MW: And I can also see how your music would be at the spearhead of that. Listen we've got to let you go because you've got to play tonight. This has been wonderful. Monk, can I put a plug in here and say can we do round two sometime? Because he's not even started, he's not even warmed up yet. But we're filming for Hamilton College Jazz Archives. We have been with one of the icons of this country in music, Herbie Hancock. Thank you.

HH: Yeah, thank you very much.